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THE ONE WHO SAT ALONE



A bedtime story about the new kid, the empty seat, and who we get to become.

BY MK PARRISH · \$14

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A NOTE BEFORE THE STORY

Almost every child, at some point, has been the one who sat alone.

The new kid. The one who talks differently, or looks different, or came from somewhere else. The one standing at the edge of the playground holding their lunch, trying to look like they don't mind, minding terribly.

This is a story for that child — and, just as much, for the children who get to decide what happens next.

It is about a girl named Juniper, who moved to a town where everything already had its place, and about the ordinary, enormous power of a single kid who chooses to scoot over. Read it warmly. And when it ends, ask the child beside you the question the whole story is really about: *when you see someone sitting alone — who do you want to be?*

THE ONE WHO SAT ALONE

When Juniper moved to the town of Elmsworth, everything there already had its place.

The birds had their branches. The shopkeepers had their corners. And the children of Elmsworth had their spots in the schoolyard — the exact same spots they'd had since they were small, sorted and settled and sure, like books on a well-loved shelf.

Juniper had no spot. She was brand new.

She came from far away, and she knew it the moment she arrived. Her clothes were a little different. She said some words in a way that made the other children's heads tilt. She didn't know the games they'd been playing forever, or the songs everyone else somehow already knew, or the hundred tiny rules that nobody wrote down but everyone followed. On her first morning, she walked into the schoolyard holding her lunch, and she looked for somewhere to sit, and every bench was already full of children who had known each other their whole lives.

So Juniper sat alone, on the low stone wall at the very edge of the yard, and she ate her lunch, and she looked like she didn't mind.

She minded terribly.

The children of Elmsworth were not cruel. That is important to know. They didn't say mean things or push her or laugh. They just... didn't make room. It's easier not to. When your shelf is already full and settled, it is easier to leave the new book on the floor than to shift everything over to fit it in. So they let Juniper sit alone, day after day, on the low stone wall at the edge of the yard.

And slowly, something happened to the story Juniper told about herself. At first she thought, *I am new here.* But after enough lonely lunches, that quiet, sad thought began to change shape, the way sad thoughts do, until it became: *Maybe there is something wrong with me. Maybe I am the kind of person who sits alone.*

That is the most dangerous part of sitting alone. It isn't the empty seat. It's the story you start to believe about why it's empty.

Now, among the children of Elmsworth there was a boy named Cass.

Cass was not the bravest child, or the most popular, or the loudest. He was an ordinary boy with an ordinary spot on an ordinary bench. But Cass had noticed the new girl on the wall. He'd noticed her the first day, and the second, and the third. And every day, a small uncomfortable feeling sat in his chest, because Cass knew a secret that the other children had forgotten:

Cass had been the new kid once, too. A long time ago, before he had his spot. And he remembered exactly what the low stone wall felt like.

For a whole week, Cass did nothing, because doing something felt enormous and scary. What if he walked over and she didn't want him there? What if the other children thought he was strange for leaving his spot? The wall was only a few steps away, but it might as well have been across the sea.

And then one grey Thursday, Cass looked at Juniper sitting alone on the wall with her face turned brave and her heart clearly breaking, and he decided that being a little scared was a much smaller thing than letting someone believe they were the kind of person who sits alone.

So Cass picked up his lunch. He walked across the yard — the whole long, terrifying, ordinary way across the yard — and he sat down on the low stone wall next to Juniper.

"This wall's better than the benches, honestly," said Cass. "You can see the whole sky from here."

Juniper looked at him, hardly daring to believe it. "You can," she said. "I noticed that too."

And that was all it took. That was the whole magic. One kid, a little scared, choosing to scoot over.

They talked, that first day, about the sky, and then about the strange words Juniper knew, which turned out not to be strange at all but *interesting*, from a place Cass had never seen. The next day, another child wandered over to the wall, curious about what was so funny down there at the edge of the yard. And then another. It turns out that once one person decides the lonely kid is worth sitting with, everybody else suddenly wonders why they hadn't thought of it first.

Within a month, the low stone wall at the edge of the yard — the loneliest spot in all of Elmsworth — had somehow become the *best* spot. The spot where the most interesting talk happened. The spot everyone wanted. And it had happened not because Juniper changed to fit the town, but because one ordinary boy changed the town to fit her.

Juniper found her place in Elmsworth after all. But that is not quite the point of the story.

The point is what Juniper did the next year, when *another* new child arrived — a small, unsure one, clutching a lunch, looking for somewhere to sit, and finding every bench already full.

Juniper watched the new child head toward the low stone wall at the edge of the yard.

And she did not wait a whole week. She did not wait a single day.

She picked up her lunch, and she walked across the yard, and she sat right down.

"This wall's the best spot in the whole school," Juniper said. "You can see the entire sky from here. Want me to show you?"

Because the one who has sat alone never forgets the feeling. And that memory, it turns out, is not a wound to hide.

It is the exact thing that lets you become the person who makes sure nobody else has to.

THE END — AND YOUR BEGINNING

Everyone is the new kid sometimes. Everyone, at least once, sits alone on the wall and starts to believe the sad, untrue story about why.

If that is you right now — if you are the one at the edge of the yard, working hard to look like you don't mind — please hear this. The empty seat beside you is not proof of anything true about you. It is only proof that the right person hasn't scooted over *yet.* You are not the kind of person who sits alone. You are a person who hasn't been found *yet.* Those are completely different stories, and you get to keep believing the true one.

And if you are Cass — if you are the one with a spot, watching someone sit alone — then this whole book was written for you most of all. Because you are holding a power so quiet you might not even know it's magic. You can end someone's loneliness in about ten steps and one sentence. You just have to be a little braver than the empty space between the benches and the wall.

When you see someone sitting alone, you get to decide who you are.

Pick up your lunch. Walk across the yard.

Go show them the sky.

This is a tale from **The Little Rewrites** *— bedtime stories from MK Parrish for children who are learning that they get to write their own happily ever after, exactly as they are. More stories, and the free read-aloud guide for grown-ups, are waiting at* **mkparrish.com.**

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